# Why 35 and Not 100

Your cancelled society event, properly diagnosed. Not a boring failure — a textbook one, in the useful sense. And the reflection nobody else will give.

Doc 40 · Replaces the diagnosis sections of doc 39 · "Tell me about a time you failed" · Prepared 4 November 2026

## 1 First: it is not a boring story

You said it feels boring. The event is ordinary. **The mechanism is not**, and the question does not reward dramatic failures — it rewards precise diagnosis.

> Here is the question nobody else in that society could answer, and you now can: **why did an event that lots of people said they would attend sell 35 tickets rather than 85?** Not zero. Not ninety. Thirty-five. That number is not random, and explaining it is real analysis.

And the mundanity helps you. It is obviously true, nothing is embellished, and a reviewer can tell. A candidate who can take a small, unglamorous failure apart properly looks more credible than one with a dramatic story they understood less well.

## 2 What actually happened, in sequence

Laying your facts out in order shows you where the error is.




Figure 1 — The sequence. Note that the DJ's pressure at step 5 exists *because* of the decision at step 2.

You already half-spotted this. You said: *"if we had targeted it more to what they want, rather than just trying to find a DJ."* That is the right instinct and it is better than you realise. You chose the product, then went looking for an audience. The order should have been the other way round.

## 3 The real diagnosis, and this is your edge

Now the deeper version, and it explains every single thing you told me.

> You sold it like a **product**. It was actually a **coordination good** — something whose value to each person depends almost entirely on how many other people are going.

Think honestly about why anyone goes to a society social. It is not the DJ. It is not the venue. **It is that other people will be there.** Nobody has ever gone to a society night because the music was objectively excellent. They go because their friends are going, because people they want to know will be there, and because they do not want to be the one who missed it.

Which means the thing you were actually selling was not an evening of music. It was *a hundred other people in a room.* And you cannot advertise that into existence by describing the DJ.

### Why this explains all three of your puzzles

| The puzzle | What the coordination framing explains |
|---|---|
| **"There was hype but nobody bought"** | Of course there was. Enthusiasm is free and it is socially pleasant to give. Buying a ticket is not free, and — crucially — **buying early means risking being one of twelve people in a room.** So everybody waits to see whether it is happening before committing, and because everybody waits, it never visibly starts happening. |
| **"35, not 85"** | 35 is roughly the number of people who will buy regardless — the committed core, the friends, the already-involved. **The next 65 were never going to buy on the strength of a poster.** They were waiting for proof it would be good, and the only proof that works is other people's tickets. |
| **"The music / venue weren't right"** | Partly true, but secondary. Better music might have moved 35 to 45. It would not have moved it to 100, because **the binding constraint was the lack of visible critical mass, not the quality of the product.** |

**THE SELF-REINFORCING BIT — SAY THIS AND YOU SOUND GENUINELY ANALYTICAL**

It gets worse than a simple shortfall. Once sales were visibly slow, **the event became less attractive, which made sales slower.** Every day it did not sell was evidence to the next person that it would not be good.

That is why these things fail fast rather than gradually. There is a threshold — below it, momentum works against you; above it, it works for you. You were below it, and every day made it worse.

## 4 Your ownership — concrete, not clever

**THE RISK WITH THE ANALYSIS ABOVE**

A clever diagnosis can read as intellectualising your way out of blame. **The economics explains the environment. It does not excuse the decision.** You must pair it with something specific you personally got wrong, or you will sound like you are describing a phenomenon that happened to you.

Here is your concrete ownership, and it comes straight from your own account:

> You mentioned it a couple of times at the meet and greet, people reacted well, and you took that as the job being done. **You treated telling people as selling to them.**

That is specific, it is undeniably yours, and it is a real mistake that real people make in real jobs. An announcement is not a sale. Nobody becomes a customer because they heard about something and nodded.

And the second concrete one, if it is true: **you let the DJ get booked before you had sold anything.** That created a break-even of 100 that you then had to chase, rather than a decision you could still make.

## 5 Why "we should have marketed it more" is the wrong lesson

This matters, because it is the instinct you had first, and it is the answer every other candidate gives.

**THE OBVIOUS LESSON**

"We didn't post regularly enough and the team wasn't coordinated on promotion. I learned we should have marketed it better and started earlier."

**Why it is wrong:** if the event was not what people wanted, and nobody could see anyone else going, then posting more often would have *advertised the wrong thing more efficiently.* It would not have fixed it.

It also quietly blames the committee, which never plays well.

**THE REAL LESSON**

"More marketing wasn't the fix. The thing people were actually buying was other people being there, and you can't advertise that — you have to build it."

**Why it is right:** it diagnoses rather than describes, it is non-obvious, and it leads to a specific different action rather than "try harder".

**SO WHAT WOULD YOU ACTUALLY DO DIFFERENTLY?**

Not "market earlier". Something concrete:

**Sell to a committed core first and make it visible.** Get thirty people to actually pay before announcing anything publicly. Then the message to everyone else is not "would you like to come to a thing?" but "thirty people are going, are you in?" **You flip the question from an uncertain purchase into joining something that is visibly happening.**

And second: do not commit the fixed cost until the floor is covered. If you have sold thirty before you book, the worst case is a small event rather than no event.

## 6 The DJ pressure, reframed

You mentioned the DJ chasing you. Handled badly this is an excuse. Handled well it closes the loop on your whole diagnosis.

**AS AN EXCUSE**

"The DJ was putting a lot of pressure on us about ticket numbers, which made everything harder."

**Reads as:** somebody else made my life difficult.

**AS EVIDENCE OF YOUR POINT**

"The DJ was chasing us for numbers, and that pressure only existed because we'd committed to paying him before we'd sold anything. The pressure wasn't the problem — it was the symptom."

**Reads as:** somebody who can trace a consequence back to its cause.

## 7 The reflection — three versions

Pick one. Each names a trade-off or a mistake and lands a lesson that is not generic.

**VERSION A — THE COORDINATION GOOD · RECOMMENDED, MOST DISTINCTIVE**

"What I got wrong was what I thought we were selling. I thought we were selling an event — a DJ, a venue, a night out — so we tried to make the event sound good. But nobody goes to a society social for the music. What people are actually buying is that other people will be there, and you can't advertise that into existence. You have to build it, by getting a visible core of people who've genuinely committed before you ask everyone else. We did it the other way round and ended up asking a hundred people to take a risk on an empty room."

**VERSION B — TELLING VERSUS SELLING · SIMPLEST AND MOST CONCRETE**

"The specific thing I got wrong is that I mentioned it a couple of times at the meet and greet, people were enthusiastic, and I took that as the job being done. But telling people about something isn't selling it to them. Enthusiasm is free, and we had loads of it. Thirty-five people actually paid. I'd been treating a free signal as if it were a real one."

VERSION C — SEQUENCING · STRONGEST IF YOU WANT A COMMERCIAL FLAVOUR

"The error was the order we did things in. We booked the DJ and the venue first, which meant we had a break-even of a hundred tickets before we'd sold one. From that point we weren't making a decision any more, we were chasing a number somebody else had set for us. If we'd sold thirty first and committed second, the worst outcome would have been a small event instead of no event — and the DJ chasing us for numbers was really just that mistake showing up later."

THE STRONGEST ANSWER COMBINES TWO

**Version B for the ownership, Version A for the insight.** B says what you personally got wrong in plain language; A shows you understand why it happened at a level nobody else will reach. Do B first, then A. Owning it before analysing it is the right order — the other way round sounds like you are explaining rather than admitting.

## 8 The full answer

About 110 seconds. Brackets are yours to confirm.

**SITUATION AND OUTCOME — ~22 SECONDS**

So this was with the economics society at university. We were putting on a social, we'd booked a DJ and a venue, and we needed to sell about a hundred tickets to cover the costs. We sold thirty-five. The DJ was chasing us for numbers, and in the end we pulled it, because running it would have put a serious loss on the society.

**WHAT I GOT WRONG, PLAINLY — ~22 SECONDS**

The specific thing I got wrong is that I mentioned it a couple of times at the meet and greet, everyone was really positive about it, and I took that as the job being done. But telling people about something isn't selling it to them. We had loads of enthusiasm. Enthusiasm is free. Thirty-five people actually paid for a ticket, and that was the only number that was ever telling me anything.

**THE DEEPER REASON — ~30 SECONDS**

And thinking about it afterwards, I don't think more marketing would have fixed it. I'd assumed we were selling an event — the DJ, the venue, the night. But nobody goes to a society social for the music. What people are actually buying is that other people will be there. So buying a ticket early means risking being one of twelve people in a room, which is why everyone waits — and because everyone waits, it never visibly starts happening. Thirty-five was basically the people who'd have come anyway. The other sixty-five were waiting for proof, and the only proof that works is other people's tickets.

**WHAT I'D DEFEND, AND WHAT I'D CHANGE — ~25 SECONDS**

I'd defend pulling it — running it half empty to avoid the embarrassment would just have added a real loss to a bad decision. But that was the right call about a hole I'd already dug. What I'd do differently is sell to a core first and make it visible. Get thirty people to actually pay before announcing anything, so what you're asking everyone else isn't "fancy coming to a thing" but "thirty people are going, are you in". And not commit the fixed cost until the floor's covered, so the worst case is a small event rather than no event.

## 9 Weak version versus yours

**WHAT EVERY OTHER CANDIDATE SAYS**

"We were running a society event but unfortunately we didn't sell enough tickets so we had to cancel it. There was a lot of pressure from the DJ."

"I think the issue was that we didn't promote it enough and the committee weren't very coordinated on posting."

"I learned the importance of marketing early and communicating as a team."

**YOURS**

"Needed a hundred. Sold thirty-five. Pulled it."

"I mentioned it twice at a meet and greet, people were positive, and I took that as done. Enthusiasm is free."

"But more marketing wouldn't have fixed it. Nobody goes to a society night for the DJ — what they're buying is other people being there, and you can't advertise that, you have to build it."

"Thirty-five was the people coming anyway. The other sixty-five were waiting for proof, and the only proof is other people's tickets."

"So: sell a visible core first, and don't commit the cost until the floor's covered."

## 10 Three warnings

**1. DO NOT REUSE YOUR HOUSE-HUNT LESSON**

In the teamwork answer, your insight was about free-riding and shrinking the ask. This one is about commitment under uncertainty. They are genuinely different — one is about effort, the other about risk — **but if you use both in the same recording they will sound like the same thought twice.** If teamwork comes up first, keep the "evidence I changed" line here to a single clause, or drop it.

**2. DO NOT BLAME THE COMMITTEE**

You mentioned "lack of internal teamwork" on posting. Leave it out. It is partly blaming other people, it is the obvious answer, and **your own analysis shows it was not the binding constraint.** Saying "more marketing wouldn't have fixed it" is stronger than diagnosing a marketing failure.

**3. DO NOT OVERSELL THE ECONOMICS**

Say it in plain words — "what people are buying is other people being there". **Do not say "network externalities" or "coordination good" out loud.** The idea is impressive; the vocabulary would make it sound like you were reaching for a term. Keep the thinking, drop the jargon.

## 11 Follow-ups

| They ask | You say |
|---|---|
| **"Couldn't you have just promoted it harder?"** | The question your analysis is built for. "We could have, and I think we'd have got to forty-five rather than a hundred. The constraint wasn't awareness — people knew about it. It was that nobody wanted to be early." |
| **"Whose fault was it?"** | "It was a committee decision, but the bit I got wrong was mine. I was the one reading the enthusiasm as demand." |
| **"Was cancelling right?"** | "Yes. The money committed was gone either way — running it would just have added a real loss on top of a bad call." |
| **"How much would you have lost?"** | [Work this out: 35 tickets × price, against the DJ fee and venue cost. Even roughly. If you do not know, say so rather than guessing.] |
| **"Have you used that since?"** | One sentence only, and not the full house story if you have already told it. |
| **"That sounds quite minor."** | Do not apologise. "It is, in the scheme of things. But it's the clearest case I've got of getting a judgement wrong and being able to say exactly why — which I'd rather have than a bigger story I understood less well." |

### THREE THINGS TO PIN DOWN BEFORE YOU FILM

**1.** Confirm the numbers — was it roughly 100 needed and 35 sold? Say "about" if you are not certain; approximate and honest beats precise and invented.
**2.** Roughly what loss did cancelling avoid? Ticket price × 35 against the DJ and venue cost. It makes the cancellation decision concrete.
**3.** Be honest with yourself about whether the meet-and-greet mentions really were the bulk of the promotion. If there was more, adjust the ownership line — but do not soften it just because it is uncomfortable. The discomfort is what makes it read as true.

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**What is mine and what is yours.** Every fact is yours: the society, the DJ, the hundred and the thirty-five, the meet-and-greet mentions, the hype without sales, the cancellation to avoid a loss. What I have added is the diagnosis — that an event of this kind is bought for who else is going rather than for its contents, that 35 represents the people who would have come anyway, that slow sales become self-reinforcing, and that the DJ's pressure was a symptom of the sequencing rather than a cause. That reading explains all three of the things that puzzled you, which is why I think it is right, but it is my interpretation of your facts and you should only say it if, having read it, you think it is true.